

The Observing Self — Leaves on a Stream

Greater Nashua Mental Health Center

Instructions: The Observing Self (ACT) is the part of you that has been watching your experiences your whole life — the constant 'you' behind changing thoughts, feelings, and roles. 'Leaves on a Stream' is a practice for stepping back into that observer perspective.

Leaves on a Stream — guided practice

- Picture a gently flowing stream with leaves drifting on the surface.
- For a few minutes, place each thought that arises onto a leaf and let it float by.
- Don't speed up or slow the stream; don't push thoughts away. Just notice and place.
- When you notice you've been swept downstream (lost in a thought), gently step back and resume.

How many times did I get 'hooked' and step back? What kinds of thoughts pulled me?

Noticing the Observing Self

Notice: the same 'you' that is aware right now is the 'you' that was aware as a child. Thoughts, feelings, and bodies change — the observer remains. This perspective is a safe place to stand.

Reflection: what is it like to be the one who notices, rather than the thoughts themselves?